Enhancing the Kingdom of Saudi Arabia as the world leader in clinical research data publishing

Business Proposal

WARAQA

In support of
VISION رؤية 2030
المملكة العربية السعودية
KINGDOM OF SAUDI ARABIA

Vision

- To demonstrate global thought leadership for open science & data publishing
- Increase research dissemination, engagement & impact
- Establish high-profile & highly-cited journal editorial boards & reviewers
- Partner with Saudi professional scientific societies
- Enable significantly improved global knowledge sharing
- Build national ecosystem for data, peer-reviewed publications, conferences & researcher collaborations

Goals

- Build modern, open-source enabled publication platforms which are interoperable with all relevant national & international databases
- Deliver simplified and single-sign on national access to evidence-based knowledge resources
- Increase number, quality & international impact of research publications, to include developing existing Saudi journals
- By publishing all data under international open science principles, increase patient & physician engagement
- Guarantee high levels of research integrity, trust & reliability of Saudi research data

Problems to be solved

- KNOWLEDGE SHARING: Inefficient sharing of knowledge between researchers, practitioners & policy makers. No unified national repository for access to research publications, data or abstracting & indexing services
- INTERNATIONAL STATUS OF SAUDI RESEARCH: Low international status & credibility. Researchers lack international profiles, impact & rankings. National journals do not have high citation impact & rankings
- OPEN SCIENCE: Currently, no national open science funding mandate. Limited open access publishing expertise. Majority of existing Saudi-affiliated journals not fully open access.
- RESEARCH INTEGRITY: Increasing reputational risk for existing & future Saudi researchers who have published in non-Saudi owned journals (e.g., 3,748 Saudi-affiliated papers published between 2017-22 now negatively impacted by Hindawi & MPDI delisting from Clarivate Journal Citation Index). Consequently, there is urgent need for greater editorial governance and focus on quality over quantity

Prioritise rebuilding research integrity

Reputation plays a significant role at individual, institutional, and national levels. The recent news article (see Nature 624, 479-481; 2023) highlighting Saudi Arabia's majority contribution to the record number of research article retractions, raises serious concerns about the credibility of its research. This lack of research integrity has impacted reputation and will greatly hinder Saudi Arabia's advancement in the field of science.

To rebuild credibility, proposed actions include developing Saudi national preprint and post-publication peer-review system, strengthening internal protocols for supervision, and establishing penalties for infringements. Similar initiatives exist for China[1] and the European Union[2].

This approach would circumvent biases, favouritism, and expert limitations, while also creating a central repository of data. Strengthening internal protocols would guide and restrict researchers, and external advisors could provide valuable expertise. Implementing penalties for infringements would deter unethical practices and emphasize the importance of adhering to research publication laws.

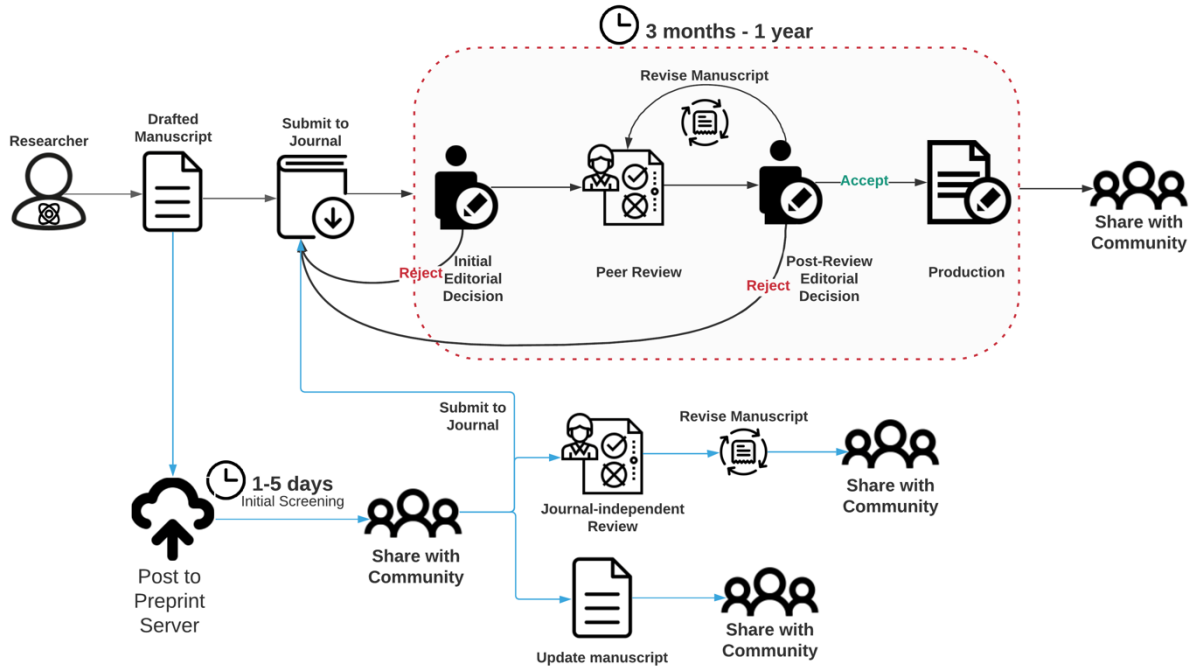
This proposal aligns with the global shift to more open and collaborative ways of working in research, including early sharing of research findings, transparent peer review, and sharing of research data.

Key components of the solution

- Creation of a national publication platform for early sharing or ‘preprinting’ of Saudi research and using an established and proven preprint platform.
- Publishing expertise and oversight by Saudi-based company and operations.
- Validation checks to the content posted on the preprint platform to ensure validity and provenance.
- Support for authors to share underpinning data for increased discoverability and improved reproducibility.
- Provision of industry standard metadata and author identifiers across the preprint venue.
- Optional English-language editing services to support researchers to disseminate their findings in English.
- Opportunity to publish policy documents, research reports, and guidelines.
- Delivery of a bespoke outreach and engagement programme for Saudi researchers.
- Flexible routes for authors to take their preprint forward to any international peer reviewed journal.

[1] ChinaAxiv https://www.chinaxiv.org/home.htm
[2] Open Research Europe https://open-research-europe.ec.europa.eu/

Preprint workflow



The preprint publishing system aims to shorten the publication cycle of research results, promote the most rapid publication and exchange of research results at the first time, and focuses on building a standardized academic exchange ecosystem. Under such a severe environment of competition, it supports the rapid pre-publication of high-level scientific research papers and effectively supports the scientists' right of research output.

Platform options

F1000 Research

F1000Research[3] is an open research publishing platform for scientists, scholars and clinicians offering rapid publication of articles and other research outputs without editorial bias. All articles benefit from transparent peer review and editorial guidance on making all source data openly available. F1000Research operates under a continuous publication schedule.

ScienceOpen

ScienceOpen[4] is a publishing platform for open access, preprints and open peer review. The platform provides a unique publishing environment embedded within a discovery and communication infrastructure of over nearly 100 million article records with essential built-in features such as preprint aggregation, open peer review and versioning that meet the full spectrum of requirements of Saudia Arabia for a preprint repository. ScienceOpen has worked with a range of multilingual publishers all over the world and has developed attractive solutions for the challenges of the Arabic language in a discovery context.

[3] F1000 Research https://f1000research.com/
[4] Science Open https://www.scienceopen.com/

Platform costs

Faculty1000

	2024	2025	2026	2027	2028	2029	5-Year Total
Publication Projections							
Articles	-	539	1,262	2,215	3,457	5,059	12,532
Costs US$							
Build cost	100,000	-	-	-	-	-	100,000
Arabic language adaptation	250,000	-	-	-	-	-	250,000
Annual maintenance		100,000	109,000	118,270	127,818	137,653	592,741
Post Publication Services/Indexing	-	37,347	95,331	167,963	288,460	445,546	1,034,646
Customer Service	-	24,009	61,284	107,976	185,439	286,422	665,130
Production/XML	-	21,341	54,475	95,979	164,834	254,598	591,227
TOTAL	**350,000**	**182,697**	**320,089**	**490,187**	**766,551**	**1,124,219**	**3,233,744**

ScienceOpen

	2024	2025	2026	2027	2028	2029	5-Year Total
Publication Projections							
Articles	-	539	1,262	2,215	3,457	5,059	12,532
Cost US$							
Build cost	20,000	-	-	-	-	-	20,000
Site navigation adaptation for Arabic	7,000	-	-	-	-	-	7,000
Annual maintenance	11,500	11,500	11,500	11,500	11,500	11,500	69,000
Annual customisation budget	-	5,000	5,000	5,000	5,000	5,000	25,000
Outreach & engagement	1,000	1,000	1,000	1,000	1,000	1,000	6,000
Pre-publication checks / SciScore	-	1,617	3,155	5,538	8,643	12,648	31,600
Oversight/Quality Assurance	-	2,695	6,310	11,075	17,285	25,295	62,660
Post Publication Services/Indexing	-	13,475	31,550	55,375	86,425	126,475	313,300
Customer Service	-	4,800	4,800	4,800	4,800	4,800	24,000
Production/XML	-	-	-	-	-	-	-
TOTAL	**39,500**	**40,087**	**63,315**	**94,288**	**134,653**	**186,718**	**558,560**

Waraqa operations

Direct costs

	2024	2025	2026	2027	2028	2029	5-Year Total
Language translations	100,000	-	-	-	-	-	100,000
Outreach & engagement	50,000	51,500	30,000	30,900	31,827	32,782	227,009
Research integrity checks	-	8,085	18,930	33,225	51,855	75,885	187,980
Content editing	-	16,170	37,860	66,450	103,710	151,770	375,960
TOTAL	**50,000**	**75,755**	**86,790**	**130,575**	**187,392**	**260,437**	**890,949**

Management costs

	2024	2025	2026	2027	2028	2029	5-Year Total
Managing Director	90,000	92,700	95,481	98,345	101,296	104,335	582,157
Executive Editor	50,000	51,500	53,045	54,636	56,275	57,964	323,420
Production Manager	50,000	51,500	53,045	54,636	56,275	57,964	323,420
Marketing Manager	40,000	41,200	42,436	43,709	45,020	46,371	258,736
TOTAL	**230,000**	**236,900**	**244,007**	**251,327**	**258,867**	**266,633**	**1,487,734**